

The Oniric Value Theorem

A Structural Criterion for Unrealizable Value in Open Systems

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Abstract

This paper introduces the *Oniric Value Theorem*, a structural criterion for identifying value that exists narratively but cannot be realized operationally. The theorem formalizes a common failure mode across financial systems, political institutions, digital platforms, and artificial intelligence: value that remains stable only as long as it is not exercised.

By connecting realizability limits to the cumulative surplus dynamics of open systems, the theorem explains why systems often appear robust until the moment realization is demanded. The framework is non-moral, non-psychological, and independent of agent intent. It provides a diagnostic tool for distinguishing operational value from narrative value before irreversible commitment occurs.

1. Introduction

There exists a precise way to lose money, time, or agency without being explicitly deceived. It does not require fraud, misinformation, or bad faith. It occurs when an agent pays for a value that exists only while it is not exercised.

This phenomenon is widespread. It appears in investment vehicles that cannot sustain withdrawals, in political rights that collapse under budgetary realization, in digital platforms that restrict expression at scale, and in artificial intelligence systems whose capabilities cannot be deployed without destabilizing their governance structures.

This paper calls such value **oniric value**: value that exists in a narrative, declarative, or representational sense, but not as an operational capacity. The *Oniric Value Theorem* formalizes the conditions under which this discrepancy arises.

2. Narrative Value vs. Operational Value

Narrative value is value that can be declared, displayed, or reported. It remains stable as long as no one attempts to exercise it fully. Operational value, by contrast, is value that survives realization: withdrawal, execution, conversion, or use.

The distinction between the two is invisible during periods of low demand. It becomes visible only when realization is attempted. At that point, systems relying on narrative value degrade, delay, excuse, or collapse.

The key claim of this paper is that this behavior is not accidental. It is structural.

3. Structural Basis

Any open system can be described minimally by two opposing functions:

- **G(t)**: a generative function producing energy, information, capability, or symbolic output.
- **Ψ(t)**: a dissipative or control function absorbing, constraining, or regulating that production.

Define the cumulative surplus function:

$$\mathbf{Aleph}(t) = \int_0^t [G(\tau) - \Psi(\tau)] d\tau$$

Every system has a finite absorptive capacity, denoted **Aleph_{max}**, determined by its architecture rather than its intentions.

When cumulative surplus exceeds this threshold, the system can no longer absorb or internalize what it has produced.

4. The Oniric Value Theorem

Theorem (Oniric Value).

If exercising a declared right, asset, or capability causes systemic degradation, delay, or collapse, then the value being exercised was narrative rather than operational.

Formally, oniric value corresponds to regimes in which:

Aleph(t) ≤ Aleph_{max},

but realization attempts force **Aleph(t) → Aleph_{max}** or beyond.

In such systems, value exists only as long as realization is deferred. Stability is maintained by non-use.

5. Diagnostic Criteria

The theorem yields a simple diagnostic test consisting of five questions:

1. Full Exercise Test

Can the value be exercised immediately and fully, without exceptional permissions or timing constraints?

2. Simultaneity Test

What happens if all holders attempt realization at the same time?

3. Conversion Test

Can the value be converted into something external to the system without asymmetric penalties?

4. Traceability Test

Is the source of the promised value operationally clear, or purely model-based or speculative?

5. Asymmetry Test

Can the issuer or manager realize value earlier or under better conditions than others?

Failure of multiple tests indicates oniric value with high confidence.

6. Relation to Open-System Realization

The Oniric Value Theorem is the experiential counterpart of the **Aleph Equation**, which defines the realizability limit of open systems:

Aleph(t) > Aleph_{max}

When this inequality holds, closure becomes structurally impossible. The system must externalize surplus through leakage, transition, or emergence.

Oniric value arises precisely in the regime where systems attempt to maintain narrative stability while approaching this threshold.

7. Applications

The theorem applies uniformly across domains:

- **Finance:** wealth that exists until withdrawal is attempted.
- **Politics:** rights that exist until budgetary realization is demanded.
- **Platforms:** freedom that exists until scale forces enforcement.
- **Artificial intelligence:** capabilities that exist until deployment exceeds institutional absorption.
- **Digital identity:** symbolic value that cannot be converted into real agency.

In all cases, the pattern is the same: value persists while unused.

8. Conclusion

The error is not believing in value. The error is failing to ask whether it can be realized.

The Oniric Value Theorem shows that unrealizable value is not a moral failure or a coordination problem, but a structural condition. Systems do not deceive by default; they function in dream mode until realization is demanded.

Value that cannot be exercised without exceeding absorptive limits does not exist to be used — only to be believed.

Author Note

This paper is released as a working paper to invite structural critique rather than empirical dispute. The framework is intended to be general, falsifiable in application, and portable across domains.